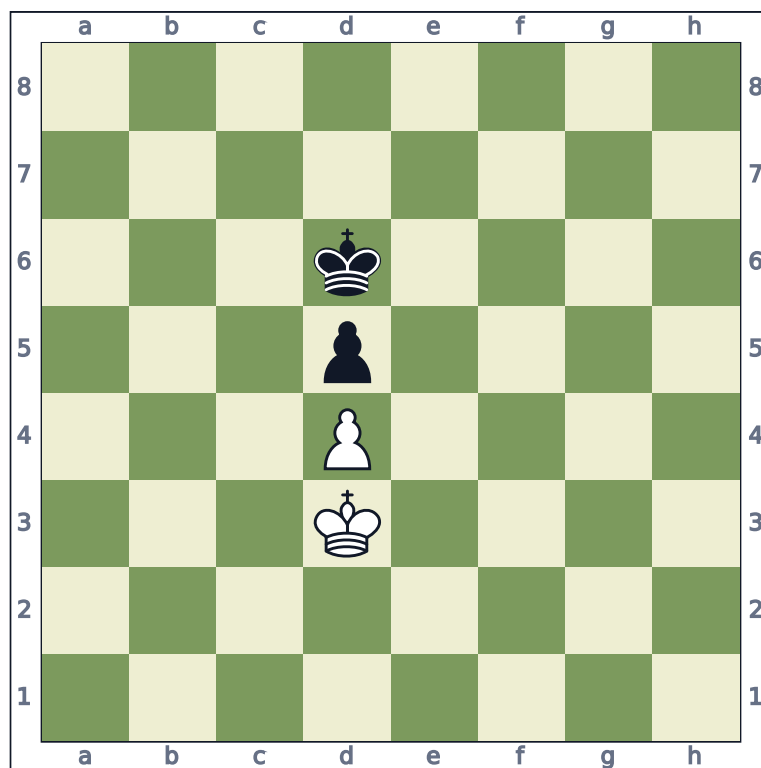


PAWN AND MINOR-PIECE ENDGAMES

Win the Key Squares

In king-and-pawn endings, identify the squares from which the king can force promotion regardless of opposition.



Illustrative endgame position - analyze the idea, not a memorized move

WHY THIS PRINCIPLE EXISTS

Key squares translate the promotion problem into king access. If the attacking king reaches one, it can escort the pawn or outflank the defender; if not, opposition may hold the draw.

THE MECHANISM

Why it works

This principle is not magic and it is not a commandment. It is a compressed prediction about promotion races, king routes, reserve tempi, and whether the remaining bishop or knight can control the critical square. The useful question is: what changes in the position when the principle is followed?

DIRECT CAUSAL MECHANISM

Key squares translate the promotion problem into king access. If the attacking king reaches one, it can escort the pawn or outflank the defender; if not, opposition may hold the draw.

BOARD GEOMETRY

With few pieces, one square can decide the game. Opposition, key squares, and the edge of the board make king geometry exact.

OPTION QUALITY

The best ending move often preserves pawn tempi or multiple king routes instead of making immediate visible progress.

TIME AND TEMPO

Every pawn move spends an irreplaceable tempo. Count races to the promotion move, including checks and captures on the way.

WHAT IT PREVENTS

It prevents a recurring class of errors by making a hidden cost visible before the move is played. The principle is valuable because that error pattern appears across many different openings and positions.

RECOGNITION

When to apply it

A principle becomes practical only when you can recognize its trigger. Use the signs below as evidence, then verify the exact position.

- Signal 1: few pieces remain.
- Signal 2: a king can approach a critical square.
- Signal 3: a pawn race or zugzwang is possible.
- Signal 4: one pawn move may spend the last reserve tempo.

FOUR-STEP APPLICATION PROTOCOL

1. Notice the trigger without choosing a move yet. 2. Generate at least two candidates, including one that follows the principle. 3. Calculate the opponent's strongest forcing reply. 4. Compare the resulting positions and apply the rule only if the concrete result supports it.

CONVERT IT INTO A BOARD QUESTION

Ask: 'Does this position give me a reason to use the following rule - In king-and-pawn endings, identify the squares from which the king can force promotion regardless of opposition.' Then ask the balancing question: 'What tactical or strategic detail could make this position an exception?'

EXCEPTIONS AND CONFLICTS

Where the slogan breaks

Chess strength comes partly from knowing when two good principles conflict. The better player does not repeat the louder slogan; they rank the actual consequences.

IMPORTANT LIMITATION

Endgame rules are exact only under their stated conditions. Count every tempo, check for stalemate, and verify promotions, captures, and underpromotions on the board.

DECISION HIERARCHY

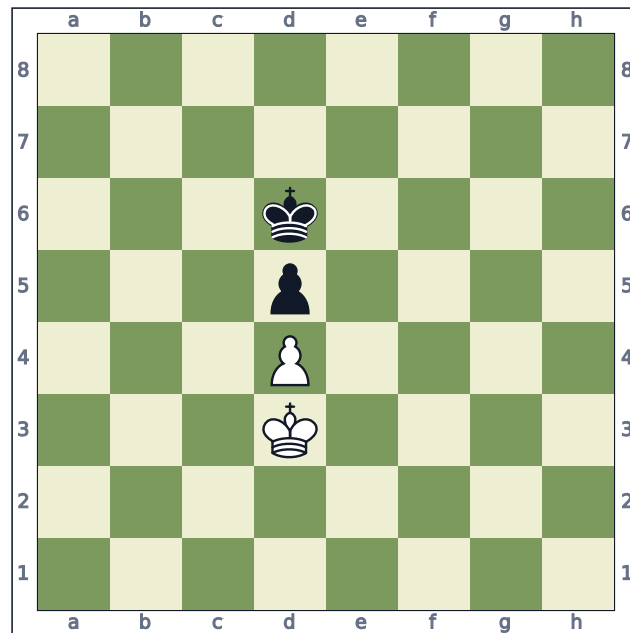
- 1. Legal and tactical survival: checks, forced mate, and immediate material loss.
- 2. King safety and forcing initiative: whose threats arrive first?
- 3. Material and conversion: what durable gain remains when activity fades?
- 4. Piece activity, structure, space, and long-term plans.
- 5. The general principle as a tiebreaker between otherwise sound choices.

RED-FLAG TEST

Before following the rule, look for one changed defender, an exposed king, an intermediate move, a pawn break, or a tactical capture. If any exists, calculate it first. A principle explains typical positions; the board decides this position.

WORKED THINKING MODEL

How a strong player uses it



Illustrative endgame position - analyze the idea, not a memorized move

1. Read the position

Start with promotion races, king routes, reserve tempi, and whether the remaining bishop or knight can control the critical square: identify the feature that will remain important after one move.

2. Find the trigger

Look for these signs: few pieces remain; a king can approach a critical square; a pawn race or zugzwang is possible; one pawn move may spend the last reserve tempo

3. Produce candidates

Include one forcing move, one move guided by the principle, and one move that prevents the opponent's best idea.

4. Verify

Calculate checks, captures, and threats for the opponent. Try to refute your preferred candidate.

5. Evaluate

Use the mechanism as the explanation, not the proof: Key squares translate the promotion problem into king access. If the attacking king reaches one, it can escort the pawn or outflank the defender; if not, opposition may hold the draw.

Note: the board is an illustration for the thinking process, not a claim that one move is forced. Set it up and compare multiple legal candidates.

TRAINING AND RETENTION

Make it automatic

PRIMARY DRILL

Collect twelve positions connected to 'Win the Key Squares'. For each, write three candidates, the opponent's strongest reply, and a one-sentence evaluation. Revisit the same positions without notes after three and seven days; score recognition separately from calculation accuracy.

SELF-TEST

- Explain the principle without using its title.
- Name two position signals that make it relevant.
- Give one reason the principle works.
- State the exception that most often causes misuse.
- Describe the calculation check required before applying it.

ANSWER RUBRIC

A strong answer connects the rule - In king-and-pawn endings, identify the squares from which the king can force promotion regardless of opposition. - to its mechanism, names a trigger from a real position, and explains this limitation: Endgame rules are exact only under their stated conditions. Count every tempo, check for stalemate, and verify promotions, captures, and underpromotions on the board.

SPACED PRACTICE LOOP

Review today, then after 3, 7, 14, and 30 days. On each review, retrieve the idea before opening the PDF. Retire it only when you can recognize the trigger in a fresh position and explain an exception.